CINEMA

FATAL ATTRACTION

In *I Want to Talk*, **Shoojit Sircar** continues his exploration of death with the portrait of a tenacious man who beats it time and again

Shoojit Sircar has learned to love the hospital. In 2004, he spent three months in one, being by the side of his comatose mother. It would lead to *October* (2018), which took audiences deep into the abyss of one and captured in vivid detail the uncertainty that comes with being on the premises. But more than that, Sircar is fascinated by death so much that it has become a leitmotif in his films, as can be seen in the gut-wrenching Jallianwala Bagh massacre sequence in *Sardar Udham* (2021) where the titular character witnesses it in such close proximity that it scars him, or how its fear lurks around Bhaskar in *Piku* (2015). Says Sircar, "After *Vicky Donor* (2012), I was like, let me face death straight on. I have to conquer this fear."

With his latest, *I Want to Talk*, which is inspired by the true story of Arjun Sen (played by Abhishek Bachchan), a US-based marketing professional who has gone under the knife 40 times at least and survived, Sircar takes it a notch farther—he laughs by highlighting the absurdity of it. "You have to do it at some point. After all, we are all going to land up there [in hospital]. Let's not resist the fact," says Sircar. "Death is inevitable, the ultimate truth. *I Want to Talk* is more or less about that closeness [to death], a man who lives on the threshold." Bachchan's Arjun is likely to draw comparisons with *Piku*'s Bhaskar with his stubborn ways which he'd rather call "persistence" and for the complex relationship he has with his daughter who has to shuttle between her divorced parents.

Sircar is an anomaly in the film industry in that he's thus far not been tied to a big studio and for the most part stays in Kolkata. Partnering with producer Ronnie Lahiri on Rising Sun Films, Sircar has found a free canvas to tell stories that don't necessarily subscribe to the traditional template of commercial cinema and for which he somehow manages to lure mainstream stars (Deepika Padukone, Varun Dhawan, Vicky Kaushal, Ayushmann Khurrana, to name a few). Sircar clarifies he isn't averse to working with other producers. "It is difficult for me to explain a lot of things, to put it in a presentation or treatment note," explains Sircar. "I am the treatment note. If somebody understands my personality, what's going in my head, then they understand the story." Writers Juhi Chaturvedi and Ritesh Shah do, so does Lahiri, and Sircar finds comfort in these collaborations.

In a storied oeuvre, *I Want to Talk* isn't Sircar's tallest work. A protracted, middling drama tackling a heavy subject, it struggles in its attempt to bring out the humour in Arjun's demeanour and predicament and thereby engage the audience. Regardless, it's still a story only Sircar could have seen and told. Says Sircar, "My problem is I am not in a hurry... I am also ageing so I don't have much time to make films. I also get bored quickly." Excuses apart, he's got a script brewing with both Shah and Chaturvedi. After all, Sircar loves a film set just as much as a hospital. ■

–Suhani Singh



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Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH